

Because most have a lavish lifestyle—and they can support such a lifestyle as long as they are earning a very high income. Technically, they may be millionaires (have a minimum net worth of \$1 million or more), but they are typically low on the prodigious accumulator of wealth (PAW) scale.

How many households in America earn \$5 million in one year? Fewer than five thousand of the nearly 100 million households. That's about one in twenty thousand. Most millionaires never earn one-tenth of \$5 million in a year. Most never become millionaires until they are fifty years of age or older. Most are frugal. And few could have ever supported a high-consumption lifestyle and become millionaires in the same lifetime.

But the lavish lifestyle sells TV time and newspapers. All too often young people are indoctrinated with the belief that “those who have money spend lavishly” and “if you don't show it, you don't have it.” Could you imagine the media hyping the frugal lifestyle of the typical American millionaire? What would the results be? Low TV ratings and lack of readership, because most people who build wealth in America are hard working, thrifty, and not at all glamorous. Wealth is rarely gained through the lottery, with a home run, or in quiz show fashion. But these are the rare jackpots that the press sensationalizes.

Many Americans, especially those in the under accumulator of wealth (UAW) category, know how to deal with increases in their realized income. They spend them! Their need for immediate gratification is great. To them, life is like a quiz show. Winners get quick cash and conspicuous gifts. Viewers of these quiz shows have lots of empathy for the contestants. Look at the top ratings such shows enjoy. People love to view their surrogate-other winning motor vehicles, boats, appliances, and money. Why don't quiz shows offer tuition scholarships as prizes? Because most people want immediate gratification. They don't want to trade a prize of, say, a camper van for eight years in night school, even though a college degree can translate into a value equivalent to more than a dozen vans.